SUMMIT x ACEMBA

ACE THE CASE 2026

AceMBA Product Management Case

Build a Better Way to Prepare for CAT, and Launch It in 30 Days

Problem Statement and Participant Instructions

> **The challenge in one line**
> Design a free, self-study platform for MBA entrance exam aspirants, then plan how to launch it using organic, free methods only.
>
> Start with real students, not with features.

Inside this document

- Instructions for Participants
- Competition Rounds
- The Case: product plan and go-to-market plan
- Submission requirements, AI policy and judging criteria
- Round 3: the finalist prototype presentation
- FAQs and the final submission checklist

Instructions for Participants

1. This edition has **one case**: the AceMBA Product Management Case. Every team solves the same problem statement, which starts on the page titled "The Case".
2. The competition runs in four rounds (see the table below). Eligibility, team size, registration and round deadlines are as published on the Unstop event page.
3. For **Round 2**, submit **one complete Word document (.docx)**. Only .docx files are accepted for the main submission. A PPT or PDF will not be accepted in its place.
4. There is no fixed page limit, but clarity is rewarded. Keep the core story in the main body and move bulky material, such as full interview transcripts, into appendices or the supporting zip.
5. Embed your key screenshots, charts, wireframes and prototype images **directly inside the Word document**. If you have a working or clickable prototype, include its link in the document.
6. If your solution includes supporting files (for example raw interview notes, screenshots, prototype recordings or datasets), compress them **along with your main Word document into a single .zip file** and upload it as one submission. The Word document must still stand on its own. Check Unstop's upload size limit and keep your zip within it.
7. File naming convention: **LeaderFirstName_TeamName_CollegeName**. For example: Ishita_Mavericks_NMIMS. Use the same name for the .docx and the .zip.
8. Include a title page with your team introduction (maximum one page) and a references section at the end. A thank-you page is not needed.
9. Deadlines are sacrosanct. Submit well in advance to avoid last-minute technical issues.
10. Any plagiarism, unauthorised use of content without references, or fabricated research (interviews, quotes, screenshots, test results or sources) will lead to disqualification.
11. The written submission must be **entirely human-authored**. You may use AI tools for research discovery and for coding or building your prototype, but AI-generated written content can lead to immediate disqualification. The full policy is in Section 7.
12. **There is no budget for this case.** Meridian Learning has not allocated any money for the launch. Your go-to-market plan must rely only on **organic and free methods**. Advertising of any kind, including paid ads, sponsored posts, paid influencers and paid promotions, is not supported or allowed in your plan.
13. Submissions will be strictly considered via Unstop through the "Submit" button available against the respective round, unless communicated otherwise.
14. All official communication will be made through **summit@nmims.in**.
15. For other issues, please refer to the Unstop page for Team SummIT POC contact details.
16. We encourage you to think critically, dive deep, and structure your approach to the best of your abilities.

Best of Luck! Hope to see you in the Grand Finale

Team SummIT x AceMBA

Competition Rounds

The competition has four rounds. Round 1 and Round 2 are elimination rounds.

Round	Name	What happens	Outcome
Round 0	Virtual Case Launch	The case and these instructions are released to all participants.	All registered teams begin
Round 1	PM Quiz	An online quiz on product management. Quiz details are shared on the Unstop page.	Elimination round
Round 2	Case Solution Submission	Teams submit one Word document covering their research, product plan and go-to-market plan, with an optional supporting zip.	Elimination round. Shortlisted teams become finalists
Round 3	Case Presentation	Finalists present a real, working prototype and answer questions from the judges. See Section 9.	Final round. Winners are decided

The Case

AceMBA Product Management Case

Build a Better Way to Prepare for CAT, and Launch It in 30 Days

Case problem statement for participating teams

Format	Team-based product management case competition
Round 2 submission	One Word document (.docx), with an optional supporting .zip, uploaded through Unstop
Budget	None. Organic and free methods only. No advertising.
Eligibility, team size and deadlines	As published on the Unstop event page
Queries	summit@nmims.in

> **In one line**
> Meridian Learning is building a free, self-study platform for MBA entrance exams, starting with CAT. Your job has two parts: design the product, deciding which features and benefits it should offer and how it personalises learning; and plan the business, deciding how to launch it to CAT aspirants in the 30 days before the exam, with no budget. Begin with real student problems, not with feature ideas.

1. The Case in Brief

Meridian Learning wants to build a free platform for students preparing for MBA entrance exams such as CAT, XAT, SNAP, NMAT and more. It will start with CAT and add the other exams over time.

Meridian Learning is a fictional learning company that already serves MBA students. It now wants to reach students earlier, while they are still preparing to get into an MBA.

What is being built	A free, platform-led, self-study product for MBA entrance exam aspirants
Which exams	CAT first. XAT, SNAP, NMAT and other management entrance exams later
What it is not	Another coaching platform built around video lectures
Design focus	Personalised learning: the product should adapt to each student's needs, gaps and pace
Price for students	Free at its core
Launch budget	None. Organic and free methods only. No advertising

Your team is Meridian's product and growth team, and you have two questions to answer:

1. **The product:** what should this platform do for students, and how should it be designed to personalise their learning?
2. **The business:** how should Meridian launch it and get it in front of CAT aspirants, given that CAT is only about 30 days away and there is no budget?

To answer them, you will find out what aspirants actually struggle with, choose which problems are worth solving, define the features and benefits that follow, build a prototype, test it with real students, build a go-to-market plan that can be executed in the next 30 days using free, organic methods, and present the whole story in a single document. The case brings together a **product plan** and a **business plan**.

2. Background: Meridian Learning

Meridian Learning is entirely fictional. It exists only to give the case a business context. You do not need to research it, and you should not try to find it.

2.1 The company today

- Meridian Learning is a learning company designed for students already enrolled in MBA programmes.
- Its products help MBA students build practical skills, prepare for internships and placements, and stay connected with peers and mentors.
- It has built trust through useful, student-first products. Its MBA students recommend it to juniors and friends.
- The company has a small product, design and engineering team, a student community and a network of MBA alumni willing to contribute their time.

2.2 Why the pre-MBA segment

Meridian Learning exists to support MBA students. But most students only discover it after they have joined a B-school. By then, a large part of their journey is behind them, and Meridian has missed the chance to help them from the start.

Meridian now wants to reach students much earlier, while they are still preparing for MBA entrance exams. To do that, it will build a **completely free learning platform** for exam preparation.

The thinking behind it is simple:

1. A student uses the free platform to prepare and finds it genuinely useful.
2. They crack their entrance exam and join a B-school.
3. They remember who helped them when it mattered, and they are far more likely to choose Meridian Learning once they are in the MBA.

In business terms, this platform is the **top of the funnel** for Meridian: a way to earn students' trust and goodwill early, rather than a product sold to them.

The platform is **not for Meridian's existing students**. It is meant for people who are preparing for MBA entrance exams right now and will join B-schools later. Meridian's aim is to give them end-to-end learning support, from the start of their preparation through to their MBA.

2.3 What leadership has decided

Decision	What it means for you
The core product is free	A student must be able to get the main value of your product without paying. Paid subscriptions cannot gate the core experience.
Not a lecture library	Video lectures cannot be the primary reason a student uses your product.
Start with CAT	Your first version is for CAT aspirants. You must show a credible path to other management entrance exams later.
About 30 days to CAT	Your launch plan must be executable in the next 30 days. A plan that only pays off after months will not score well.
No budget	Meridian has allocated no money for this launch. You must use organic and free methods only. Advertising of any kind is not supported or allowed.
A lean team	Assume a small team. State clearly what your plan needs in time and effort.
Evidence over opinion	Leadership will not fund a product, or a launch plan, based on assumptions. Every major claim must be backed by real evidence.
Build small, think big	You do not have to build everything. You do have to think everything through.

3. Your Challenge

> **Design a free, platform-led, self-study product that helps CAT aspirants prepare more effectively, with personalised learning at its centre, and that is meaningfully different from what exists today. Then show how Meridian can launch it to CAT aspirants within the 30 days before the exam, using only organic and free methods.**

The challenge is open-ended. There is no pre-selected winning feature and no prescribed solution. We are not looking for the longest feature list. We are looking for the clearest understanding of a real problem and the best product and business thinking in response to it.

To succeed, your team must be able to answer six questions:

1. **Who** is the aspirant you are designing for, and what are they trying to get done?
2. **What** goes wrong in their preparation today, and how do you know?
3. **Why** do existing tools and workarounds fall short?
4. **What** is the smallest product that would deliver a complete, useful outcome?
5. **How** do you know it works, based on real users trying it?

6. **How** will CAT aspirants find out about it, and how do you win your first users in the 30 days before CAT without spending any money?

4. The Problem Space

CAT and other management entrance exams demand a mix of skill-building, consistent practice, learning from mistakes and performance under time pressure. Students use coaching platforms, mock tests, question banks, books, free resources, peer groups and self-made plans.

Your job is to find out where the friction really is. Below are areas for investigation. **They are prompts, not findings, and not mandatory features.** Do not assume a problem exists because it sounds plausible.

Area	Questions worth investigating
VARC (Verbal Ability and Reading Comprehension)	How do students deal with unfamiliar words? How do they interpret a difficult passage, judge tone or inference, choose between close answer options, and learn from mistakes?
DILR (Data Interpretation and Logical Reasoning)	How do students pick which sets to attempt? How do they represent information, handle constraints, manage time, recover when stuck, and review failed attempts?
Quant (Quantitative Aptitude)	Where are the concept gaps and missing prerequisites? Which errors are calculation slips versus method errors? How do students choose a method, and how do they revise?
Cross-section	How do students decide what to practise next? How do they stay consistent, revise weak areas, track progress and use mock-test feedback?

One illustration, to show the kind of thinking we mean: a student reading a VARC passage may hit unfamiliar words and either stop to look them up, losing flow, or skip them and lose meaning. A tool that helps them understand such words in context, without leaving the passage, is one possible idea. This is **not** a finding and **not** a recommended solution. It may or may not be a real problem for the students you speak to. Your research should tell you.

You must investigate all three sections and the cross-section experience, even if your final MVP focuses on a narrower problem. The depth of your research on each is part of how you will be judged.

5. How the Case Works: Six Stages

Work through the stages in order. Do not skip to ideas before you have evidence.

Stage One: Research Before Ideation

You must complete both **primary research** (talking to students) and **competitor analysis**.

1.1 Interview real students

Conduct **at least 25 genuine interviews** with people who are currently preparing for CAT or another management entrance exam, or who prepared recently. We expect most teams to land between 25 and 30. More is welcome, but quality matters more than quantity.

- Aim for variety: different preparation stages, methods, backgrounds, scores and levels of experience.
- Include students who found preparation difficult, not only those who did well.
- Ask open-ended questions about **real, recent behaviour**, not opinions about hypothetical products.

Explore things such as:

- How they planned and carried out their most recent study session
- A recent question, passage or set they found hard, and what they did next
- How they decide what to practise, revise or attempt next
- Which tools they use now, what they like, and what workarounds they rely on
- What they tried that did not work, and why
- Where they find preparation advice and resources, whom they trust, and what makes them try something new (this feeds your go-to-market plan)

Interview discipline:

- Do not lead participants toward your preferred solution.
- Record what people actually said, and keep it clearly separate from your own interpretation.
- Get consent before recording or quoting anyone.

1.2 Analyse the competition

Review relevant preparation platforms and adjacent tools. Look beyond marketing pages: go through the actual user journey and note features, pricing or access limits, feedback mechanisms and the quality of the experience.

- Which needs are already served well?
- Where is there friction, or a gap?
- What do students do outside these platforms to fill the gaps?
- How would your product be meaningfully different, not merely a copy with extra features?

Cite every source. Distinguish what you observed yourself from what you read elsewhere.

1.3 Keep auditable evidence

Your research must be traceable. Include:

- Anonymised interview transcripts or detailed interview notes
- Evidence IDs, dates and participant context (without identifying details)
- Genuine screenshots where relevant, for example WhatsApp conversations, study-group messages, shared study plans or workarounds students showed you
- An **evidence register** that links each major finding to the interview IDs, notes or screenshots behind it

> **Evidence standard:** Every major pain point and important claim must trace back to real evidence. Do not fabricate, embellish, or present assumptions as facts. Where your evidence is thin, say so. Honesty about limitations is rewarded.

Stage Two: Define and Prioritise the Problems

Turn your research into a clear **problem map**, organised by VARC, DILR, Quant and cross-section needs.

For each shortlisted pain point, explain:

- Who experiences it, and in what situation
- What the student is trying to achieve
- What goes wrong or takes unnecessary effort
- How often and how severely it occurs, based on your research
- The workaround students use today
- Which evidence supports it, and where that evidence is limited

Then **rank the problems with a transparent method.** You may consider user impact, frequency, severity, unmet need, feasibility and differentiation. Explain your criteria and the trade-offs you made. An unexplained score will not earn credit.

Stage Three: Design the Product

Turn your chosen problems into one connected product, not a disconnected set of tools.

3.1 Product strategy

- Define your **primary user segment** and the specific job the product helps them complete.
- Write a clear **value proposition**: why would a student choose this over today's alternatives?
- State your **product principles** and main **differentiators**.
- Explain how the product **stays free at its core**. You may suggest sustainable operating approaches, but focus on user value and feasibility, not unsupported revenue forecasts.
- Explain how the product could later support **other management entrance exams** without compromising the first experience.

3.2 Feature blueprint

Think through the **full** feature set your product needs, including how it personalises learning for each student. For every feature, document:

Element	What to write
Problem addressed	The evidence-backed pain point
Intended outcome	What changes for the student
How it works	The user flow or logic, including how it adapts to the individual student

Element	What to write
Evidence	Which interviews or artifacts support it
Priority	MVP or later, with the reason
Dependencies	What must exist first
Success measure	An observable outcome

Every proposed feature must be properly considered, even if you never build it.

3.3 Define the MVP

Separate the minimum viable product from later releases. Choose a small set of features that together deliver a **complete, useful outcome** for the student. Explain what you deliberately left out, and why.

Stage Four: Prototype the Experience

Design a prototype that makes your product understandable and credible. It should demonstrate the **core user journey**, not just attractive screens.

4.1 What the prototype must show

- A clear entry point and a coherent path through the core task
- Realistic sample content: questions, answer states and feedback
- Meaningful interactions for the key features you selected
- A consistent visual system: typography, spacing, colour, hierarchy and components
- Sensible behaviour on both mobile and desktop where relevant
- A clear label for what actually works and what is an illustrative mockup

4.2 Building it

A working or clickable prototype is **strongly encouraged**, and it becomes central in Round 3. You may use Google AI Studio, Lovable or any other suitable design or development tool. You do not need to implement every feature. Focus on the most important part of your solution.

The interface must feel clean, professional and usable. It must **not** look generic or obviously AI-generated. Review and refine what the tools give you. Avoid placeholder copy, repetitive layouts, inconsistent components and decoration that does not help the user.

> **Quality over screen count.** A few coherent, realistic and tested screens beat many disconnected ones. We are judging product thinking and usability, not only visual polish.

Stage Five: Validate and Improve

Test your prototype with real target users. Where possible, include students who were **not** in your original interview set.

- Give participants a realistic task and do not coach them through it.

- Observe where they hesitate, misunderstand or fail.
- Record genuine feedback, and separate **observations** (what you saw) from **opinions** (what they said they felt).
- Show what you changed after testing, or explain why you chose not to.
- Do not claim improved usability or satisfaction without evidence.

Stage Six: Plan the Go-to-Market

A good product that nobody finds is not a business. Meridian needs this platform in front of CAT aspirants quickly, and it needs a plan that a small team can actually carry out. This stage is the business half of the case. You can work on it alongside Stages Four and Five.

> **Two hard constraints**
>
> **CAT is about 30 days away.** Your plan must be executable in the next 30 days by a small team. Aspirants are in the final stretch of preparation, so every day counts. Plans that take months to show results will not score well.
>
> **There is no budget.** Meridian has allocated no money for this launch. Your plan must use **organic and free methods only**, such as community participation, useful content, partnerships, referrals and word of mouth. **No advertising is supported or allowed**: no paid ads, sponsored posts, paid influencers or any other paid promotion. Plans that rely on spending money will lose marks.

6.1 Understand the launch context

- Which aspirants are you targeting right now, and at what stage of preparation? Students a month before CAT behave differently from those who are just starting for next year.
- Where do they spend their time and get preparation advice today? Use your Stage One interviews: ask where they find resources, whom they trust, and what makes them try something new.
- What would make a student try an unfamiliar free platform in the last month before the exam, and what would make them come back?

6.2 Map the channels and communities

Build a broad picture of the free and organic ways CAT aspirants can be reached. Think about online communities (Reddit is one example), messaging groups, social and video platforms where you can post for free, professional networks, question-and-answer sites, college clubs and alumni networks, student ambassadors and peers who might share it for free, and anything else your research turns up. These are prompts, not a checklist.

For each channel you consider, note:

- The audience and how aspirants actually use that channel
- The specific communities, groups or creators, not just the platform name
- The rules and etiquette of the community, such as limits on self-promotion
- Reach, where you can verify it, plus effort and speed to results
- The risks

Then **prioritise the channels with a transparent method.** You might weigh relevance to aspirants, speed, effort, trust, how much control you have and how well the channel fits a free product. Explain your criteria and trade-offs.

6.3 Go deep on your top three strategies

Choose **three** strategies and develop each into a complete, end-to-end implementation plan. For each, include:

Element	What to write
Objective and audience	Who you are reaching and the result you want
Why this channel	The evidence that it fits your target students
Offer and message	Positioning, the hook, and what the student gets
Assets needed	Posts, demos, tools, referral mechanics or partnerships to prepare, all at zero cost
Execution plan	Day-by-day or week-by-week actions across the 30 days
Roles and effort	Who does what, and roughly how many hours
Cost	Zero spend. List the free tools, time and partnerships you rely on
Metrics	Targets across reach, visits, sign-ups, activation and return, and how you will track them for free
Risks and fallbacks	What could go wrong, and when you would double down or drop it

6.4 Bring the plan together

- A **30-day launch calendar** covering all three strategies, running up to CAT.
- **Product readiness:** which parts of your MVP must be live by when, and what you do if they are not ready.
- **Combined targets** and how you will judge success after the first week.
- A **resource plan:** team, free tools and time. State clearly that no money is required.
- How early users' feedback will flow back into the product.

6.5 Rules for the go-to-market plan

- **No budget, no advertising.** Organic and free methods only. Any plan that includes paid promotion of any kind will lose marks.
- **Base it on evidence.** Say where your channel choices come from: interviews, observation or public data. Do not invent audience sizes, conversion rates or traction. Label every estimate and assumption.
- **Play fair.** No spam, fake accounts, fake reviews or misleading claims. Plans that depend on breaking a community's or platform's rules will lose marks.
- **Free stays free.** Growth tactics must not put the main value of the product behind a paywall.
- **Keep it executable.** Plan what a small team can really do in 30 days.

6. What You Must Submit in Round 2

Submit **one complete Word document (.docx)** that tells the story from research to solution to launch. Judges should not have to reconstruct your work from separate files.

#	Section	What it must contain
1	Executive summary	Target user, the most important validated problem, proposed solution, differentiation, MVP and the headline of your launch plan
2	Research methodology	How you recruited participants, your interview approach, dates, sample profile and limitations
3	Primary research evidence	At least 25 real interviews, anonymised transcripts or detailed notes, and an evidence register. Relevant screenshots included
4	Competitor analysis	Products reviewed, comparable features, observed gaps, sources and what it means for your product
5	Pain-point map	Evidence-backed findings for VARC, DILR, Quant and cross-section needs, with your prioritisation rationale
6	Product strategy	Target segment, user problem, value proposition, differentiation and free-product principles
7	Feature blueprint	All proposed features with flows, personalisation logic, rationale, priorities, dependencies and success metrics
8	MVP definition	What is built first, what is deferred, and why
9	Prototype evidence	Screenshots embedded in the document, plus a link to the working or clickable prototype if you have one
10	User validation	Testing method, real observations, feedback and the iterations that followed
11	Roadmap and measurement	A phased plan, key metrics, assumptions, risks and dependencies
12	Go-to-market plan	Channel and community map with prioritisation, your top three organic strategies with complete implementation plans, a 30-day launch calendar, the free tools and time required, and metrics
13	AI and tools disclosure	Which tools you used, how you used them, and a confirmation that the written narrative is entirely your own

Suggested flow: Title page → Executive summary → Research → Competitor analysis → Pain points → Product strategy → Feature blueprint → MVP → Prototype → Validation → Roadmap → Go-to-market plan → AI and tools disclosure → References and appendices.

6.1 Screenshots and supporting files

- Embed key screenshots, charts, wireframes and prototype images **directly in the Word document**.

- If your supporting files are large or numerous, compress them together with your Word document into **one .zip file** and upload it as a single submission on Unstop. The Word document must stand on its own; the zip cannot replace it.
- Put your prototype link inside the Word document. A zip cannot hold a live prototype, so a short screen recording of the prototype is a good backup to include in the zip.
- Use anonymised participant IDs and clear file names.
- Redact names, phone numbers, profile photos and unrelated content from screenshots and chats. Do not share private conversations without consent.

7. AI-Use and Originality Policy

This is the most important rule in the competition. Please read it carefully.

> **The written submission must be human-authored.** AI-generated text must not appear in your submitted document. Submissions found to contain AI-generated written content may be disqualified immediately.

This covers AI-written or AI-rewritten paragraphs, summaries, recommendations, interview quotations, research findings, analysis, feature descriptions, go-to-market plans and presentation copy.

What is permitted

- Using AI to help you **discover** research: finding public sources or generating search terms, as long as you independently verify every claim.
- Using AI-assisted **coding, design or prototyping tools** to build your prototype.
- Using AI for **technical troubleshooting**, or to understand how a tool works.
- Using spelling and basic formatting tools, as long as they do not generate or rewrite your substantive narrative.

What is not permitted in the written submission

- Submitting AI-generated text, even if lightly edited, paraphrased or translated.
- Using AI to write or rewrite the executive summary, research synthesis, recommendations, feature rationale, roadmap or go-to-market narrative.
- Fabricating interviews, quotations, survey responses, screenshots, user-test results, competitor findings or citations.
- Presenting AI-generated content as something a participant said, or as an independently verified fact.

How we verify

Your team is responsible for the authenticity of every claim. Organisers may ask for raw notes, version history, source material or a short explanation of your reasoning. If something is flagged, you may be asked to explain or substantiate it. Keep your working files, your original interview notes and your document history.

The prototype may be built with AI-assisted tools. You must disclose this and make sure the result is coherent, usable and professionally refined.

8. How You Will Be Judged in Round 2

Evaluation prioritises **evidence-based product thinking and a realistic business plan** over the number of features or the polish of the document.

Criterion	Weight	What judges look for
User research and evidence quality	20%	Depth and authenticity of interviews, quality of evidence, understanding of competitors, and honesty about limitations
Problem definition and prioritisation	15%	Clarity of pain points, user impact, evidence-backed ranking and the quality of your trade-offs
Product strategy and differentiation	15%	A coherent value proposition, relevance of the solution, personalisation at its core, and a real distinction from existing products
Prototype and user experience	20%	Usability, visual quality, coherent flows, realistic interactions and fit with the problem identified
Go-to-market and business plan	20%	Evidence-based channel and community choices, clear prioritisation, three complete and executable strategies, and a realistic 30-day plan that uses only organic, free methods
Feasibility, validation and metrics	10%	A practical MVP scope, quality of validation, roadmap, dependencies and measurable success criteria

What strong submissions tend to look like:

- They contain specific, even surprising, findings that could only have come from real conversations.
- They are candid about what the evidence does not show.
- They pick a narrow problem and solve it well, rather than a broad one and solve it shallowly.
- Their prototype and launch plan clearly follow from the research.
- Their launch plan is creative within a zero budget and is specific about communities, messages and timing.

What weak submissions tend to look like:

- They begin with a feature idea and look for evidence afterwards.
- Their findings are generic and could have been written without talking to anyone.
- They copy the feature set of an existing platform.
- The interface is attractive, but the problem it solves is unclear.
- Their launch plan is a list of platform names, or quietly depends on paid ads.

9. Round 3: The Finalist Prototype Presentation

Finalists move to Round 3. Because this is a product management competition, Round 3 is about the **product itself**. Finalists present a real, working prototype and defend their thinking in front of the judges.

- **Build a real, working prototype.** Spend your time making the product work rather than polishing slides and documents.
- **Documents and decks are optional.** You are welcome to expand on what you submitted in Round 2 and keep developing your document or a presentation deck if it helps you tell your story. There is **no slide limit**.
- **Show the core journey.** The prototype should take a student from entry to a complete, useful outcome with realistic content, and should reflect what you learned from user testing.
- **Expect questions.** Judges will ask about your research, your decisions and your launch plan, and may try the prototype themselves.
- **Prepare for things to break.** Keep a stable link and a backup screen recording of the prototype.
- **Clickable prototypes count.** If your team has no developer, a clickable prototype built in a design tool is acceptable as long as the core journey works end to end.

Judges will consider, in order of importance:

1. Product thinking and how well the product fits the problem
2. Quality of the prototype and the core user journey
3. Use of evidence and validation, including how well the team handles questions
4. The go-to-market plan and how clearly it is communicated

The presentation format and time slot will be shared with finalists.

10. Ground Rules

- **The core experience must be free.** A paid subscription cannot be required to access the main value of your solution.
- **No budget and no advertising.** Your launch plan must use organic and free methods only. Paid advertising and any other paid promotion are not allowed.
- **Original work only.** Do not copy proprietary content, question banks, designs or code from existing platforms. Use original work or appropriately licensed material.
- **Cite your sources.** Label estimates, assumptions and hypotheses as such.
- **Consent and privacy.** Use only research data collected with appropriate consent, and anonymise personal information in the final submission.
- **Scope.** You are not required to build every feature. Prioritise a useful, feasible MVP and explain the rest of your roadmap.
- **Research first.** A beautiful interface cannot make up for a weakly researched problem.
- **Meridian Learning is fictional.** Do not contact real companies claiming to represent it.

11. Practical Guidance for Teams

Plan backwards from your Round 2 deadline on Unstop. A suggested way to split your time:

Share of your time	Focus	Output
First 40%	Plan research, build your interview guide, recruit participants, run interviews, complete competitor review	Interview notes, evidence register, competitor shortlist
Next 20%	Synthesise, build the problem map, prioritise, decide your focus	Pain-point map and ranking rationale
Next 25%	Product strategy, feature blueprint, MVP definition, prototype build, channel and community mapping	Strategy, blueprint, working or clickable prototype, channel map
Final 15%	Test with users, iterate, finish the go-to-market plan, write and check the final document	Validation notes and finished submission

Tips

- Start documenting from the first interview. It is very hard to reconstruct evidence later.
- Write down exact words students use. Their language often reveals the real problem.
- Look for what students **do**, not only what they say they want.
- Talk to students you do not know. Friends tend to be polite.
- Ask your interviewees where they discover and trust preparation resources. It is the best raw material for a go-to-market plan.
- Write the document yourselves as you go, rather than leaving it to the end.

12. Frequently Asked Questions

Can we interview students from our own college? Yes, but try to include people outside your immediate circle and from varied backgrounds.

Does the product have to cover all three CAT sections? No. You must *investigate* all three, but your product can focus on a narrower problem if your evidence supports it.

Can we use the VARC vocabulary example from this brief? Only if your own research shows it is a real, significant problem. It is an illustration, not a hint at the answer.

Do we have to build a working app for Round 2? No. A working or clickable prototype is strongly encouraged, but a well-designed set of coherent screens with a clear journey is acceptable. In Round 3, finalists present a real working prototype.

Do we need a PPT for Round 2? No. Round 2 is a Word document only.

Can we share a Google Drive link instead of a zip? No. Upload everything through Unstop, in a single .zip with your Word document if you have supporting files. A link to a live prototype inside the document is fine.

Can we use AI to polish our English? No. AI-written, rewritten or translated text is not permitted in the submission. Basic spelling and formatting tools are fine.

Can the product include video? Video cannot be the primary value of your product. Small supporting uses are acceptable if your research justifies them.

Can we use real students' screenshots? Only with their consent, and only after redacting names, phone numbers, photos and unrelated content.

Can our launch plan include paid ads or paid influencers? No. There is no budget, and advertising of any kind is not supported or allowed. Use organic and free methods only.

Do we have to actually run the launch? No, you plan it. You may include small real tests that cost nothing, such as a post to gauge response, if you follow each community's rules and report the results honestly.

Our top three strategies overlap. Is that a problem? Not necessarily, but each strategy should have its own objective, message and plan. Judges will look for three genuinely distinct approaches.

13. Final Submission Checklist

Before you submit, confirm each item:

☐ We interviewed at least 25 real students and documented our methodology.

☐ We completed competitor analysis using verifiable sources.

☐ Our major pain points are linked to real evidence in an evidence register.

☐ We investigated VARC, DILR and Quant, plus cross-section needs.

☐ We prioritised features and explained what is in the MVP versus later.

☐ Our prototype demonstrates a coherent core user journey.

☐ We tested the prototype with real users and documented what we learned.

☐ Our go-to-market plan maps a broad set of channels and communities and explains how we prioritised them.

☐ We developed our top three strategies into complete plans that can be executed in the 30 days before CAT.

☐ Our plan uses only organic and free methods, with no advertising or paid promotion of any kind.

☐ The Word document includes key screenshots and evidence, and our prototype link.

☐ Our file is named LeaderFirstName_TeamName_CollegeName, and any supporting files are in a single .zip with the document.

☐ All external sources are cited and all assumptions are labelled.

☐ We disclosed our AI and tool use, and the written narrative is entirely our own.

☐ All sensitive participant information has been anonymised.

> **The principle to remember:** Do not start with features. Start with students. Understand their real problems, build the smallest useful product that solves those problems exceptionally well, and find your first users without spending a rupee.

AceMBA Product Management Case | Meridian Learning is a fictional company created for this case.